

How to Make a Winning Offer on a Home in New Braunfels

Offer price alone doesn't win homes in New Braunfels. Here's how earnest money, option fees, terms, and timing come together to create an offer sellers actually accept.

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Most buyers in New Braunfels spend weeks finding the right home and then treat the offer like an afterthought. That's a mistake. In a market where well-priced homes in desirable areas still attract serious interest, the way you structure your offer — the price, the earnest money, the option fee, the timeline, and the contingencies — determines whether you get the home or watch someone else move in. This guide breaks down exactly how the Texas offer process works and what separates offers that get accepted from those that don't.

THE TEXAS CONTRACT

What You Are Actually Signing When You Make an Offer in Texas

Texas uses a standardized purchase contract called the One to Four Family Residential Contract (Resale), published by the Texas Real Estate Commission (TREC). Unlike some states where offers begin as a simple letter of intent, a Texas real estate offer is a legally binding contract from the moment it's signed by both parties.

The Contract Is the Offer

In Texas, there is no separate offer letter or letter of intent stage for residential transactions. When your agent prepares your offer, they are completing the full TREC contract with your proposed terms. The seller either accepts it, counters it, or rejects it — but from execution forward, both parties are bound by its terms. Every blank in the contract matters: price, earnest money, option fee, option period length, closing date, financing terms, and any special provisions.

EARNEST MONEY

Earnest Money: How Much Is Right in New Braunfels in 2026

Earnest money is a good-faith deposit you make when your offer is accepted, held in escrow by the title company until closing. It signals to the seller that you are a serious buyer — and it is at risk if you

back out without a valid contractual reason after the option period ends.

The Norm and Why Going Higher Can Help

In New Braunfels in 2026, a standard earnest money deposit typically runs 1% of the purchase price. In competitive situations — multiple offers, a highly desirable property — going to 1.5% or 2% sends a meaningful signal without changing your actual risk profile much, since you recover the deposit at closing either way. Sellers and listing agents pay attention to earnest money because it reflects the buyer's financial commitment.

What Happens to Earnest Money If the Deal Falls Through

If you terminate during the option period, your earnest money is returned regardless of reason. If the transaction falls through after the option period for a reason covered by a contract contingency — the home doesn't appraise, financing falls through — the contract specifies what happens. If you back out without a valid contractual reason after the option period ends, the seller is generally entitled to keep the earnest money as liquidated damages.

When Earnest Money Is Due and Who Holds It

Earnest money is typically due within 3 business days of contract execution, wired or delivered to the title company — not to the seller's agent or seller directly. Always confirm wiring instructions with the title company directly and be alert to wire fraud — this is a real risk in real estate transactions.

THE OPTION PERIOD

The Option Period: Texas's Most Buyer-Friendly Contract Feature

The option period is a Texas-specific feature that makes buying here more buyer-friendly than most other states. During it, you have the unrestricted right to terminate the contract for any reason and receive your earnest money back in full. You pay the seller a small, non-refundable option fee for this right.

Option Fee vs. Option Period Length

The option fee is typically \$100 to \$500 on a standard residential transaction. In competitive situations, offering a higher option fee or a shorter period can make your offer more attractive. In a softer market or on a property with known concerns, negotiating a longer period gives you more time for thorough due diligence.

What to Accomplish During the Option Period

Complete your general home inspection and any specialty inspections, review the seller's disclosure notice, obtain a homeowner's insurance quote, and confirm utility availability, flood zone status, and

HOA documents. After the option period ends, your exit options narrow considerably — treat every day of it as valuable.

Negotiating After the Option Period

If your inspection reveals issues, your agent prepares an Amendment to Contract requesting repairs or a price reduction. The seller can accept, counter, or decline. If you can't agree and you're still within the option period, you can terminate and recover your earnest money. Once the option period expires, you've given up your unrestricted right to walk away.

OFFER PRICE STRATEGY

How to Think About Offer Price in New Braunfels in 2026

Getting price strategy right means reading the specific conditions of the property you're making an offer on — not applying a blanket approach to every listing.

Analyzing Days on Market and Price History

A home listed 3 days ago with multiple showings is a different situation than one sitting for 45 days with a price reduction. Days on market (DOM) and any price history are public data your agent can pull. A long DOM or prior price cut indicates a motivated seller with room to negotiate. A fresh listing in a desirable area may warrant coming in at or above list.

Escalation Clauses and Appraisal Gap Coverage

An escalation clause instructs the seller to increase your offer above any competing offer by a set increment, up to a maximum. It can be effective in true multiple-offer situations but reveals your ceiling and can complicate negotiations. Appraisal gap coverage — agreeing to cover a gap between appraised value and purchase price up to a set amount — reduces the seller's risk that the deal falls apart at appraisal and should only be used when you've run the numbers and are comfortable with the downside.

TERMS THAT MATTER

Offer Terms That Influence Sellers as Much as Price

Price is what most buyers focus on. Sellers and listing agents look at the full picture — and terms can make a lower-priced offer more attractive than a higher one.

Closing Date and Leaseback Agreements

Sellers have their own timelines. Asking your agent to find out the seller's preferred closing date before submitting — then aligning accordingly — costs nothing and can differentiate your offer

meaningfully. A seller leaseback allows the seller to remain in the home for a set period after closing, paying the buyer rent. Offering a 30 or 60-day leaseback can make your offer significantly more attractive to a seller in transition, with no change to the purchase price.

Financing Strength and Pre-Approval Quality

A pre-approval letter from a well-known local lender carries more weight than one from an online lender the listing agent has never worked with. Conventional financing with 20% down presents less perceived risk to the seller than FHA or VA — even though VA and FHA deals close successfully every day. Cash offers eliminate financing risk entirely. Understanding how your financing type is perceived and compensating for it in other terms is part of a thoughtful offer strategy.

AFTER YOU SUBMIT

What Happens After Your Offer Is Submitted

Once your agent submits your offer, sellers typically respond within 24 to 48 hours. Understanding the possible responses keeps you from making emotional decisions when a counter comes back.

- **Acceptance:** both parties sign the contract and the transaction is official. Earnest money is due within 3 business days.
- **Counter-offer:** the seller modifies your terms and returns it for your signature. You can accept, counter again, or walk away.
- **Multiple counter-offers:** in competitive situations, the seller may ask all buyers for highest-and-best offers by a deadline.
- **Rejection:** the seller declines without a counter. Your agent may be able to find out why, informing your next steps.
- **Backup offer position:** if the seller is already under contract, they may ask if you want to be in backup position — sometimes a smart play on a property you really want.

Frequently Asked Questions

How much earnest money should I offer on a home in New Braunfels?

The standard in 2026 is approximately 1% of the purchase price — \$4,500 on a \$450,000 home. In a competitive multiple-offer situation, going to 1.5% or 2% signals seriousness without materially increasing your risk, since earnest money is returned at closing or if you terminate during the option period.

What is the option period in Texas and how long should I ask for?

The option period is a Texas-specific window — typically 5 to 10 days — during which you have the unrestricted right to terminate and recover your earnest money. You pay the seller a small, non-refundable option fee (usually \$100 to \$500) for this right. Never waive the option period on a first home purchase.

Should I offer over asking price in New Braunfels right now?

It depends entirely on the specific property. A fresh listing in a desirable area with active showings may warrant at-or-above-list. A home sitting 45 days with a price reduction has room to negotiate below list. Your agent should pull comparable sales and current market data for that specific neighborhood before advising on price.

Can I make an offer without a pre-approval letter?

Technically yes, but practically no — most listing agents will not present an offer without one, and sellers will not take it seriously. Get pre-approved before you start touring homes, not after you fall in love with one.

What is a leaseback and when does it make sense to offer one?

A seller leaseback allows the seller to remain in the home for a set period after closing, paying the buyer a daily rent. It is most useful when the seller has not yet found their next home. Offering a leaseback can make your offer meaningfully more attractive at no cost to you in purchase price.

What does 'highest and best' mean and how should I respond?

When a seller receives multiple offers, they may ask all buyers to submit their highest-and-best offer by a deadline. This is typically your one shot — assume you will not get another chance. Come back with the offer you would be comfortable losing on: raise your price if there's room, increase earnest money, improve terms, and remove contingencies you can live without.

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